



English Mastered

ENGLISH MASTERED · MARITIME ENGLISH

Maritime Technical English Course

Module 4 — Cargo, Claims & Safety

Cargo handling, damage claims, and professional dispute resolution — with a grammar focus on Past Simple and Past Continuous for describing incidents at sea.

ESP · ENGLISH FOR SPECIFIC PURPOSES

Objective

This module focuses on cargo handling, damage claims, and professional dispute resolution in the maritime industry. You will build vocabulary for different cargo types and damage terminology, and develop the formal communication skills needed to handle claims through phone calls and emails.

By the end, you will be able to describe an incident clearly, notify and respond to a claim in writing, negotiate a settlement diplomatically, and explain cargo-hold safety procedures with confidence.

GRAMMAR FOCUS

Distinguishing between the Past Simple and Past Continuous tenses to describe exactly when and how damage occurred.

In this module

- 1 Cargo types and damage.** Cargo classifications, damage categories, key vocabulary, and the Past Simple / Past Continuous contrast.
- 2 Claims and dispute resolution.** The claims process, professional phone dialogues, negotiation language, and formal email writing.
- 3 Cargo holds and safety.** Hold structures, enclosed-space safety procedures, grammar practice, and writing tasks.

SECTION ONE

Cargo Types and Damage



Types of Cargo

Understanding the different types of cargo is essential for maritime professionals. Each type has specific handling requirements, risks, and documentation needs — affecting everything from vessel selection to insurance and claims procedures.

Dry Bulk Cargo. Unpackaged commodities loaded directly into the ship's holds — grain, coal, iron ore, cement, and fertilisers. Measured by weight and carried on specialised bulk carriers.

Liquid Bulk Cargo. Fluids transported in tanks rather than containers: crude oil, petroleum products, chemicals, liquefied natural gas (LNG), and vegetable oils. Tanker vessels are designed specifically for these cargoes.

Containerised Cargo. Goods packed in standard shipping containers (TEU/FEU) — electronics, textiles, consumer goods, and manufactured products. Container ships offer efficient loading and secure transport.

Break Bulk Cargo. Individual units loaded separately rather than in containers: steel coils, machinery, vehicles, and project cargo. These require careful stowage and specialised handling equipment.

Reefer Cargo. Temperature-controlled goods requiring refrigerated containers or vessels — fresh produce, frozen food, pharmaceuticals, and other perishables.

Types of Cargo Damage

Cargo damage can occur at any point during transport. Recognising the different types helps professionals identify causes, assign responsibility, and process claims effectively.

Wet Damage. Caused by water ingress from rain, seawater, condensation, or leaking containers. Often affects dry bulk cargo, paper products, and electronics, and may result from improper hatch sealing or container damage.

Contamination. When cargo becomes polluted by contact with other substances — cross-contamination between cargoes, residue from previous shipments, or exposure to harmful materials during handling.

Shortage. When the quantity delivered is less than the quantity stated in the bill of lading, resulting from theft, miscounting, spillage, or losses during handling.

Physical Damage. Structural damage including dents, tears, crushing, or breakage — often during loading or discharge, or from improper stowage causing cargo to shift during the voyage.

Delay-Related Damage. Occurs when cargo arrives late, particularly affecting perishable goods, time-sensitive materials, or commodities with fluctuating market values.

Temperature Damage. Damage to reefer cargo when proper temperatures are not maintained, including thawing of frozen goods or spoilage of fresh produce.

Key Cargo Vocabulary

Stowage

The arrangement and securing of cargo in a vessel's holds.

Manifest

A detailed list of all cargo carried on a vessel.

Tally

The count or record of cargo loaded or discharged.

Pilferage

Theft of small quantities of cargo.

Sweat Damage

Moisture damage from condensation inside holds or containers.

Stevedore

A worker who loads and unloads vessels.

Shipper

The person or company sending the cargo.

Bill of Lading (B/L)

The document acknowledging receipt of cargo for shipment.

Survey

An inspection to assess the condition of cargo or a vessel.

Outturn

The quantity of cargo delivered at the destination.

Spillage

Loss of cargo through accidental spilling.

Inherent Vice

Damage caused by the nature of the cargo itself.

Consignee

The person or company receiving the cargo.

WHY IT MATTERS

These terms appear throughout bills of lading, survey reports, and claim correspondence. Knowing them precisely is the difference between a clear claim and a costly misunderstanding.

Past Simple vs Past Continuous

When describing incidents in maritime contexts, we often use both tenses together. Understanding the difference lets you explain exactly when and how damage occurred.

Past Simple — **completed actions**

Used for actions that started and finished at a specific time.

The cargo was damaged. The container fell. The vessel arrived.

Past Continuous — **actions in progress**

Used for actions that were ongoing at a particular time in the past. Formation: was/were + verb-ing.

The crew was loading the cargo. The stevedores were operating the crane.

USING BOTH TOGETHER

Use the Past Simple for the main event and the Past Continuous for the background action that was happening when the event occurred.

The cargo was damaged while it was being discharged.

The container fell while the crane was operating.

The cargo got wet while the crew was loading the vessel.

The damage occurred while stevedores were working on deck.

Past Continuous in Context

Common maritime verbs and how they appear in the Past Continuous when setting the scene for an incident.

BASE FORM	PAST CONTINUOUS	EXAMPLE IN CONTEXT
load	was/were loading	<i>The crew was loading containers.</i>
discharge	was/were discharging	<i>The vessel was discharging cargo.</i>
operate	was/were operating	<i>The crane was operating at full speed.</i>
transport	was/were transporting	<i>The truck was transporting goods.</i>
inspect	was/were inspecting	<i>The surveyor was inspecting the hold.</i>
sail	was/were sailing	<i>The ship was sailing through rough seas.</i>
wait	was/were waiting	<i>The vessel was waiting for berth allocation.</i>
negotiate	was/were negotiating	<i>We were negotiating the charter terms.</i>
review	was/were reviewing	<i>The P&I club was reviewing the claim.</i>

KEY POINT

When writing damage reports or explaining incidents, use the Past Continuous to set the scene and the Past Simple for the specific event that caused the damage.

"While the vessel was discharging at berth 7, a container was dropped."

"The cargo was contaminated while it was being transferred to storage."

SECTION TWO

Claims and Dispute Resolution



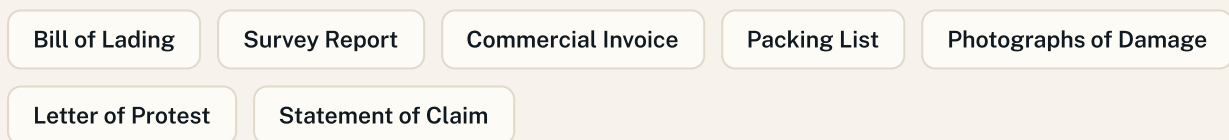
Cargo Claims

When cargo is damaged, a formal claims process begins, involving the shipper, consignee, ship owner, charterer, and insurers. Professional language and clear documentation are essential to resolving disputes.

The claims process

- 1 Discovery.** The consignee discovers damage upon receipt of cargo.
- 2 Notification.** The receiver notifies the carrier and shipper of the damage.
- 3 Survey.** An independent surveyor inspects the cargo and issues a report.
- 4 Claim Filing.** The claimant submits a formal claim with supporting documents.
- 5 Investigation.** The carrier investigates the circumstances of the damage.
- 6 Negotiation.** Parties discuss responsibility and potential settlement.
- 7 Resolution.** The claim is settled, rejected, or proceeds to arbitration.

Key documents



Sample Phone Dialogue

Discussing a cargo damage dispute professionally — note how both past tenses pinpoint when the damage occurred.

BROKER Good morning. I'm calling regarding the cargo damage claim for the MV Atlantic Star.

OWNER Good morning. Yes, I received the notification. What are the details?

BROKER The cargo was damaged while it was being discharged at Rotterdam.

OWNER I understand. Do you know when exactly the damage occurred?

BROKER The surveyor's report indicates the damage occurred while stevedores were operating the crane.

OWNER So the damage happened during terminal operations, not while at sea?

BROKER That appears to be the case, but the receiver insists responsibility remains with the vessel.

OWNER We will need to review the survey report carefully. The matter is under review.

BROKER I understand. When can we expect your response?

OWNER We should have our position ready within 48 hours.

BROKER Thank you. I will inform the charterer and revert if needed.

Negotiating Responsibility

BROKER We have reviewed the survey report. Would you consider a shared settlement?

OWNER What exactly are you proposing?

BROKER The charterer suggests splitting the claim 50/50 to avoid prolonged disputes.

OWNER We may agree to a settlement if further claims are withdrawn.

BROKER I will need to consult with the charterer on that condition.

OWNER Please also confirm the total amount being claimed.

BROKER The claim totals USD 45,000 based on the commercial invoice value.

OWNER We are prepared to consider USD 22,500 as a full and final settlement.

BROKER I will revert after consulting the charterer. Thank you for your flexibility.

OWNER We are open to a reasonable resolution. Please confirm by end of day.

USEFUL NEGOTIATION PHRASES

"Would you consider a shared settlement?"

"We are prepared to offer a commercial solution."

"The matter is under review."

"I will revert after consulting with my principal."

"We are open to a reasonable resolution."

Formal Email — Claim Notice

KEY FEATURES OF THIS EMAIL

Clear subject line identifying vessel and voyage · uses Past Simple and Past Continuous correctly · states facts objectively without assigning blame · references attached documentation · requests acknowledgement and response.

To: owners@atlanticshipping.com **From:** broker@oceanbrokers.com

Cargo Damage Claim — MV Atlantic Star — Voyage 2024-127

Dear Sirs,

We write to formally notify you of cargo damage that occurred during the discharge of the above vessel at Rotterdam on 15 January 2025.

During discharge operations, three containers were damaged while being lifted from the hold. The surveyor confirmed that the damage occurred while the containers were being transferred by the terminal crane.

The receiver has documented the damage and intends to file a formal claim. We attach the preliminary survey report and photographs for your review.

Please acknowledge receipt and advise your position at your earliest convenience.

Best regards,

John Smith — Ocean Brokers Ltd.

Email Reply — Ship Owner

NOTICE THE TECHNIQUE

The owner acknowledges receipt, presents facts from the Master's log, and uses the Past Continuous ("were being handled," "was changing shifts") to locate responsibility with terminal operations — all without open accusation.

To: broker@oceanbrokers.com **From:** owners@atlanticshipping.com

RE: Cargo Damage Claim — MV Atlantic Star — Voyage 2024-127

Dear Mr. Smith,

Thank you for your notification dated 16 January 2025 regarding the above claim. We have reviewed the preliminary survey report and wish to provide our initial position.

According to our records, the cargo was properly secured before discharge commenced. The Master's log confirms that all cargo was in good condition when discharge operations began at 0600 hours on 15 January.

The damage appears to have occurred during terminal operations while the containers were being handled by shore equipment. We note the surveyor's report indicates the crane operator was changing shifts when the incident occurred.

We are currently reviewing the survey report in detail and will revert with our full response within 48 hours.

Best regards,
Maria Chen — Atlantic Shipping Co.

Settlement Proposal Email

SETTLEMENT LANGUAGE

"full and final settlement" · "commercial settlement" / "commercial solution"

"without prejudice" (protects future legal position) · "subject to contract"

"shared responsibility"

From: broker@oceanbrokers.com

RE: Cargo Damage Claim — Commercial Settlement Proposal

Dear Ms. Chen,

Further to our telephone conversation earlier today, we are pleased to confirm the charterer's proposal for a commercial settlement.

Given the circumstances surrounding the incident and the shared interest in avoiding prolonged disputes, the charterer proposes a 50/50 split of the claim amount.

The total claim value is USD 45,000. Under this proposal, each party would contribute USD 22,500 as full and final settlement of all claims arising from this incident.

We believe this represents a fair and reasonable solution that allows all parties to move forward. Please confirm your acceptance by close of business Friday.

Best regards,
John Smith

SECTION THREE

Cargo Holds and Safety

Cargo Holds

A cargo hold is an enclosed space designed to carry cargo. Understanding hold structures is essential for proper loading, stowage, and safety. Different vessel types have different configurations based on their intended cargo.

Types of cargo holds

Single Hold. One large cargo space, typically on smaller vessels. Simple design but limited flexibility in cargo segregation.

Multiple Holds. Several separated compartments allowing different cargoes to be carried simultaneously without cross-contamination.

Box-Shaped Holds. Rectangular design for easier loading and cleaning. Common on container ships and general cargo vessels.

Hopper-Sided Holds. Common on bulk carriers; angled lower sides improve cargo flow during discharge and enhance vessel stability.

Cargo hold structures

Hatch Covers

Large steel covers that seal the cargo hold opening.

Tank Tops

The bottom plating of the cargo hold (double-bottom ceiling).

Bilge Wells

Low points in the hold where water collects for pumping.

Coamings

Raised edges around the hatch opening to prevent water ingress.

Frames & Bulkheads

Structural supports and watertight divisions.

Ladders

Access points for entering and exiting the cargo hold.

Cargo Hold Safety

Entering cargo holds can be dangerous. Enclosed spaces may contain hazardous atmospheres from cargo residues, fumigation chemicals, or oxygen depletion. Strict procedures must be followed before anyone enters.

Safety procedures before entry

- ✓ Ventilate the cargo hold thoroughly before entry.
- ✓ Test the atmosphere for oxygen levels (must be 19.5–23.5%).
- ✓ Check for toxic gases (H₂S, CO, fumigants).
- ✓ Obtain an entry permit from the responsible officer.
- ✓ Establish communication with a standby person outside.
- ✓ Ensure rescue equipment is available, and use appropriate PPE.
- ✓ Never enter alone without a standby person.

SAFETY LANGUAGE (PASSIVE VOICE)

"The cargo hold was ventilated before entry."

"Oxygen levels were checked and found safe."

"Access was restricted due to safety concerns."

"The atmosphere was tested at 0800 hours."

"Entry was prohibited until the permit was issued."

Grammar Practice

Complete the sentences using the Past Simple or Past Continuous.

- 1 The cargo _____ (get) wet while the crew _____ (load) the vessel.
- 2 The container _____ (fall) while the crane _____ (operate).
- 3 The receiver _____ (notice) damage after discharge _____ (finish).
- 4 The vessel _____ (delay) because loading _____ (take) longer than expected.
- 5 The cargo _____ (damage) while it _____ (transport) to the warehouse.
- 6 The surveyor _____ (arrive) while the crew _____ (secure) the hatches.
- 7 The broker _____ (call) while we _____ (review) the survey report.
- 8 The hold _____ (flood) while the vessel _____ (sail) through the storm.

ANSWER KEY

1. got, was loading · 2. fell, was operating · 3. noticed, finished · 4. was delayed, was taking
5. was damaged, was being transported · 6. arrived, were securing · 7. called, were reviewing · 8. flooded,
was sailing

Writing & Speaking Tasks

TASK 1 · EMAIL

Damage claim email

Write a formal email from a broker to a ship owner notifying them of cargo damage. Include the type of cargo, when the damage occurred, what was happening at that time, and a request for response. Use both Past Simple and Past Continuous.

TASK 2 · EMAIL

Reply email

Write a reply from the ship owner. Include acknowledgement of the claim, an explanation of events from the owner's perspective, a reference to the survey report, and a professional closing.

TASK 3 · EMAIL

Settlement proposal

Write a follow-up email proposing a commercial settlement. Use the Past Simple to explain what happened, cause-and-effect language, and a polite negotiation tone.

TASK 4 · SPEAKING

Describe an incident

Describe a damage incident orally. Mention the type of cargo, what happened, when it happened, what was going on at the time, and who was responsible.

TASK 5 · SPEAKING

Safety briefing

Describe the cargo hold and explain the safety steps before entering. Use appropriate safety vocabulary and the passive voice where suitable.

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END OF MODULE 4

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